

Project Cleanup

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Fast and smart ways to maintain your hard disk

Invalid system disk. Insert system disk and press any key to continue.—the dreaded hard disk failure or file system corruption message that none of us ever want to see, but chances are that most of us will, at some point or another! Most of us don't really take care of our hard disks; we just install programs blindly, and dump all sorts of junk onto it. Only when we see this message, or run out of disk space, do we even bother to clean it up. In order to make our hard disks last and perform better, all that is needed is a little tender, loving care (TLC).

The hard disk, by far, is the most important component of your PC. If your processor blows up, you get a new one; the same goes for the motherboard, RAM, or any other components, but the day your hard disk crashes, it's time to worry. Not only does your PC come to a stand still, but all your presentations, movies, music, documents and valuable data is probably lost forever. Sure, you can try to recover it, but that's a tedious process and most often, you will fail miserably. At best, you can format, reload the operating system and cross your fingers and pray that this time, it will last a bit longer.

Call in the sweepers

In order to keep your hard disk in

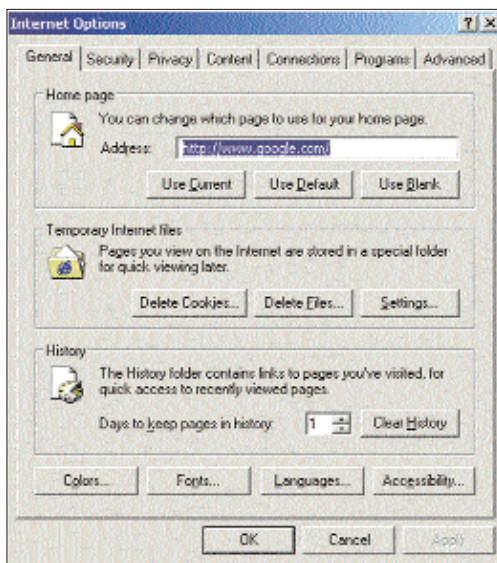
shape, the most basic requirement is a thorough cleanup. You need to delete all the junk that was installed by programs during their installations. To do this, go to the **Windows\Temp** folder, and delete all the files there. Now, empty the Recycle Bin by right-clicking on it and selecting 'Empty Recycle Bin'. The next step is to clear all useless Internet files from Internet Explorer. Go to Tools > Internet Options in Internet Explorer. Here, click on Delete Cookies, Delete Files (select the 'Delete all Offline Content'

checkbox), and Clear History.

Besides these basic measures, there are third-party applications, such as WindowWasher and Norton CleanSweep that clean your hard disk for you.

Norton CleanSweep: Norton CleanSweep lets you select the files you want to remove to clean your hard disk. Start the CleanSweep wizard through **Start > Programs > Norton SystemWorks > Norton CleanSweep > Cleanup > Norton Fast & Safe Cleanup**. In the main dialog box, click on Settings and select all the options given, including the Temporary Internet Files. This will remove all traces of your junk data. Click on OK, and in the main window, click on Clean Now. This will clean all the junk files, and show a report of the total bytes freed up. Close the window, and return to the SystemWorks window.

You can also go to **Norton SystemWorks > Norton CleanSweep > Internet**, and select the 'Internet Cache Cleanup and Cookie Cleanup' option. This will clean up the cookies accumulated while surfing the Internet. Alternatively, you can select the ActiveX Cleanup and Plug-in Cleanup for removing outdated or unused plug-ins, or ActiveX controls that Internet Explorer downloads automatically.



Using Internet Options, delete all the temporary files created while surfing